

GRADE 8 · READING INFORMATIONAL TEXT · RI.8.1

Strongest Evidence Workshop

Cite the textual evidence that most strongly supports an analysis of explicit statements and inferences drawn from an informational text.

Lesson Map · Passage · Guided · Partner · Independent Practice · Small Group · Answer Key

What You Will Learn Today

Learning Goals

Understand RI.8.1: Cite the textual evidence that most strongly supports an analysis of e...

Read an original passage closely

Support every answer with text evidence

Work through guided, partner, and independent practice

How the Lesson Runs

Warm-up and passage

Guided practice together

Partner discussion

Independent + small-group work

Exit ticket and answer key

Unpacking the Standard

In informational text, explicit evidence often appears as stated facts, data, or direct quotations from sources. An inference in informational text is a reasonable conclusion drawn from combining facts, not a claim the text states outright. At grade 8, choosing the "strongest" evidence means comparing multiple possible pieces of support and explaining why one is more precise, more directly relevant, or more reliable than another.

Modeled Example

A report states "the bridge was inspected in 2019" and separately "engineers recommended repairs in March 2024 after finding corrosion in support cables." Which detail more strongly supports an inference that the bridge's condition worsened over time, and why?

The second detail is stronger, because it directly identifies a specific problem (corrosion) and a specific recommendation for repair, while the first detail alone only establishes a date and says nothing about the bridge's condition.

If a text states a company's profits and separately quotes an employee saying morale was low, which is stronger evidence for an inference about employee experience, and why?

The employee quote is stronger for an inference specifically about employee experience, because it comes from a direct source describing that experience, while profit figures describe financial results and only indirectly relate to how employees felt.

How One City Rebuilt Its Public Library System

1. In 2015, the city of Millbrook faced a decision: renovate its aging central library or close two of its three branches to cut costs. The central library, built in 1962, had not been substantially updated in over fifty years. Its roof leaked in four places, and its basement archive had flooded twice in the previous decade.
2. City council member Rosa Ibarra argued against closures. "A library is not a luxury," she told the council in a recorded session. "For some families, it is the only place with reliable internet, air conditioning in summer, and a quiet room to study." Her statement was backed by a city survey showing that 38 percent of library visitors used the building for internet access alone.
3. Opponents of renovation pointed to cost. Estimates from the city engineer placed the renovation at \$4.2 million, compared to an estimated \$600,000 in annual savings from closing two branches. At that rate, opponents argued, renovation would take seven years just to break even.
4. The council commissioned an independent study in 2016. The study found that library usage had actually increased by 22 percent over the previous five years, driven largely by after-school programs and job-search workshops for adults. It also found that the two branches proposed for closure served neighborhoods with the city's lowest average household income.

How One City Rebuilt Its Public Library System

5. In 2017, the council voted 5–2 to renovate rather than close branches, funding the project through a mix of municipal bonds and a state library-improvement grant. Construction began in 2018 and was completed in early 2020, just before a period when library usage nationally would shift significantly due to public health measures.

6. By 2023, three years after renovation, Millbrook's library system reported that overall visits across all three branches had risen 41 percent compared to 2015 levels. The after-school program alone served over 900 students that year, more than triple its 2015 enrollment of 280.

7. Rosa Ibarra, no longer on the council but still a frequent visitor, was asked in a 2023 newspaper interview whether the investment had been worth it. She pointed not to the usage statistics but to a single detail: the renovated building now had four public meeting rooms, all booked solid most weeknights, used by tutoring groups, citizenship-class students, and a monthly repair café where residents fixed broken appliances instead of throwing them away.

Warm-up · Before You Read

1. What does paragraph 1 state explicitly about the library's physical condition before renovation?
2. Which piece of evidence most strongly supports the inference that low-income families would be most affected by branch closures, and why is it stronger than other available evidence?

Guided Practice

3. What explicit statistic does the city survey provide about internet access, according to paragraph 2?

4. What is the strongest evidence for an inference that renovation opponents were focused mainly on short-term cost rather than long-term community impact? Explain your choice.

Guided Practice

5. What explicit finding did the 2016 independent study report about library usage trends?

6. Between the 22 percent usage increase and the finding about low-income neighborhoods, which more strongly supports the council's eventual decision to renovate rather than close branches? Justify your answer.

Partner Discussion

7. What explicit vote result is stated in paragraph 5?

8. What can you infer about the timing of the renovation's completion from paragraph 5? Cite the strongest evidence.

Partner Discussion

9. What explicit statistic does paragraph 6 give about overall visit growth by 2023?

Independent Practice

10. Which is stronger evidence that the after-school program specifically drove the increase in usage: the 22 percent five-year increase from 2016, or the tripling of after-school enrollment mentioned in paragraph 6? Explain.

11. What explicit detail does Rosa Ibarra point to in paragraph 7 when asked if the investment was worth it?

Independent Practice

12. Why might Rosa Ibarra's choice to cite meeting-room usage, rather than the 41 percent visit increase, be considered strong evidence of her personal view? Explain using the text.

13. Explain the difference between an explicit fact and an inference using two examples from this article.

Independent Practice

14. A reader claims the article proves renovation was purely a financial success. Using the strongest evidence, explain why this claim oversimplifies the article.

15. Which piece of evidence in the article is least useful for supporting an inference about community impact, and why?

Small-Group Work

16. Identify one place in the article where two different inferences could reasonably be drawn from the same evidence, and explain both.

17. What explicit detail from paragraph 4 identifies which programs drove the usage increase, and why is it stronger evidence than simply citing the 22 percent figure alone?

Small-Group Work

18. Why does the article include the detail that construction finished "just before" a period of national change in library use? What inference does this support?

19. Compare the strength of Rosa Ibarra's 2015 survey statistic (paragraph 2) to the 2023 enrollment statistic (paragraph 6) as evidence for the renovation's long-term success. Which is stronger, and why?

Exit Ticket

20. Write one full inference about the value of the renovation to the community, and identify the single strongest piece of evidence that supports it, explaining why it beats at least one other candidate detail.

Answer Key (1 of 4)

1. The roof leaked in four places, and the basement archive had flooded twice in the previous decade.

2. The finding in paragraph 4 that the branches proposed for closure served neighborhoods with the city's lowest average household income is strongest, because it directly and specifically connects closure to income level, unlike Rosa Ibarra's general statement about libraries being important, which does not specify which neighborhoods would be affected.
3. 38 percent of library visitors used the building for internet access alone.

4. The strongest evidence is that opponents calculated renovation would "take seven years just to break even" (paragraph 3), a purely financial comparison; this is stronger than simply noting they opposed renovation, because it shows their argument was built specifically around a break-even cost calculation rather than community outcomes.
5. Library usage had increased by 22 percent over the previous five years.

Answer Key (2 of 4)

6. The finding about low-income neighborhoods is somewhat stronger for justifying renovation specifically over closure, because it identifies a direct equity consequence of closing branches, while the usage increase shows the library was valuable but does not by itself argue against closing the two lower-use branches.

7. The council voted 5–2 to renovate rather than close branches.

8. The renovation was completed at a fortunate time, just before increased public reliance on libraries; the strongest evidence is the phrase "just before a period when library usage nationally would shift significantly due to public health measures," which directly signals a timing connection without stating the outcome explicitly.

9. Overall visits across all three branches had risen 41 percent compared to 2015 levels.

10. The tripling of after-school enrollment (from 280 to over 900 students) is stronger, because it isolates one specific program's growth, while the 22 percent figure is a broader usage statistic that could be caused by many different factors, not just after-school programs.

Answer Key (3 of 4)

11. The four public meeting rooms, booked solid most weeknights with tutoring groups, citizenship-class students, and a repair café.

12. It suggests she values the library's role as a community gathering space more than raw visitor numbers; the text explicitly says she "pointed not to the usage statistics but to" the meeting rooms, showing a deliberate choice to emphasize a different kind of evidence than the official statistics.

13. Explicit: the article directly states the renovation cost \$4.2 million (paragraph 3). Inference: a reader must conclude that community programs, not just building repairs, drove the growth in usage, since the article never states this as a single direct claim but supports it with several related facts.

14. The claim oversimplifies the article because the strongest evidence of impact, such as the growth in after-school enrollment and the daily use of meeting rooms, describes community and educational outcomes, not financial ones; the article never presents a direct financial return figure to support a claim of purely financial success.

15. The \$4.2 million renovation estimate (paragraph 3) is least useful for that specific inference, because it is a cost figure that describes the investment itself rather than any outcome or effect on the community.

Answer Key (4 of 4)

16. The 5–2 council vote (paragraph 5) could support either "most council members were convinced by the equity findings" or "two members had unresolved concerns about cost"; both are reasonable, since the article states the vote but does not explain the two dissenting votes.

17. The article explicitly states the increase was "driven largely by after-school programs and job-search workshops for adults"; naming the specific programs is stronger evidence than the 22 percent figure alone, because it explains the cause of the growth rather than just reporting that growth happened.

18. It supports the inference that Millbrook's renovation was fortunately timed, which strengthens the case that the investment paid off, since the newly renovated building was ready right as broader demand for library services likely shifted.

19. The 2023 enrollment statistic is stronger evidence of long-term success, because it measures an actual outcome years after renovation was completed, while the 2015 survey statistic only measured need before the renovation happened and cannot by itself confirm the investment worked.

20. Answers vary; require a clear inference plus one specific cited detail, with an explanation of why that detail supports the inference more strongly than at least one other available detail from the article.

Exit Ticket

Answer on a sticky note

Answer the exit-ticket question from today's lesson.

Cite at least one piece of evidence from the passage.

Remember

Name your claim or answer

Quote or cite the evidence

Explain how it supports your answer